CURRICULUM VITAE | Olaf Borghi

Doctoral Candidate in Psychology · **Royal Holloway, University of London**
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Key research terms: emotional and cognitive factors in political belief and attitude formation, future anxiety and support for democracy, adolescent development, causal inference and Bayesian statistics

Education

since 2023	**Doctoral Candidate in Psychology** | Royal Holloway, University of London *Supervisors: Manos Tsakiris, Kaat Smets* MSCA Doctoral Network Interdisciplinary Perspectives on the Politics of Adolescence & Democracy · ippad.eu Working thesis: *Cognitive and emotional contributions to the making of the political mind*
07/2023	**M.Sc. in Psychology** | University of Vienna | graduated with honours *Supervisors: Magdalena Boch, Claus Lamm* Track: Social Neuroscience, Cognitive Psychology and Research Methods Thesis: *Modulation of the Action Observation Network: Investigating Action, Agent and Observer Factors in an fMRI Study*
07/2021	**B.Sc. in Psychology** | University of Vienna | with distinction *Supervisor: Ulrich Tran* Thesis: *Differential associations of the two higher-order factors of mindfulness with trait empathy and the mediating role of emotional awareness*

Research Experience

04–07/2025	**Visiting Researcher** | Joint Research Centre, European Commission *Unit for Science for Democracy and Evidence-Informed Policymaking · Brussels, Belgium*
2021–2023	**Student Research Assistant** | University of Vienna *Social, Cognitive and Affective Neuroscience Unit · MRI data collection · supervised by Magdalena Boch & Claus Lamm*
2022–2023	**Research Intern** | University of Vienna *Psychological Methods · applied statistics and mindfulness research · supervised by Ulrich Tran*
2020	**Research Intern** | University of Vienna *Comparative Canine Neuroimaging Unit · MRI data collection · supervised by Magdalena Boch*

Teaching Experience

2022–2023	**Student Teaching Assistant** | Psychological Methods, University of Vienna *Methods and Statistics tutor · supervised by Frank Scharnowski*
2020–2021	**Student Tutor** | Department of Developmental and Educational Psychology, University of Vienna *Supervised Orientation Tutorial for first-year students · supervised by Birgit Leidenfrost and Christoph Burger*

Workshops taught

11/2025 **Borghi, O., & Kasper, J.** Data visualization in the social and cognitive sciences using ggplot2. *IP-PAD Meeting Training Day, Amsterdam.* Workshop materials

Awards & Prizes

2026 **Elaine Funnell Prize** | Royal Holloway, University of London (£750).

2026 **Early-career sponsorship** | Workshop *Politics and Mental Health in Times of Societal Threat* (€500).

2024 **Academic Excellence Scholarship** | University of Vienna (€931)

2023 **Academic Excellence Scholarship** | University of Vienna (€750)

2022 **Academic Excellence Scholarship** | University of Vienna (€750)

Publications

Peer-reviewed articles

2026 **Borghi, O.**, Tappin, B. M., Smets, K., & Tsakiris, M. (2026). Mind over bias: How is cognitive control related to politically motivated reasoning? *Cognition, 268*, 106373. doi.org/10.1016/j.cognition.2025.106373

2025 **Borghi, O.**, Niraki, M., Seremeta, E., Smets, K., & Tsakiris, M. (2025). Facing a dark future: Young people's future anxiety and political attitudes in the UK and Greece. *Advances.in/Psychology, 2*, e555124. doi.org/10.56296/aip00042

2024† **Borghi, O.**, Mayrhofer, L., Voracek, M., & Tran, U. S. (2024). Day-to-day associations between mindfulness and perceived stress: Insights from random intercept cross-lagged panel modelling. *Frontiers in Psychology, 15*. doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2024.1272720

2023† **Borghi, O.**, Mayrhofer, L., Voracek, M., & Tran, U. S. (2023). Differential associations of the two higher-order factors of mindfulness with trait empathy and the mediating role of emotional awareness. *Scientific Reports, 13*(1). doi.org/10.1038/s41598-023-30323-6

Reports and commentaries

2026 Arahal, I.*, **Borghi, O.***, Ratnam, R.,* Smets, K.*, & Tsakiris, M.* (2026). Willing but Wary: Adolescents, Democracy & Vote at 16: the IP-PAD UK Adolescent Study. https://www.royalholloway.ac.uk/media/zhbnbovl/willing_but_wary_ip-pad_adolescent_report.pdf

2025 **Borghi, O.***, & Shankar, S.* (2025). A comment on 'Bayesianism and wishful thinking are compatible'. *I4R Discussion Paper Series No. 198*, Institute for Replication. hdl.handle.net/10419/309441

2024 **Borghi, O.***, Arahal, I.*, Smets, K.*, & Tsakiris, M.* (2024). *The IP-PAD Youth Survey UK Report*. IP-PAD Network. ippad.eu/post/youth-survey-uk

Pre-prints, submitted manuscripts, and manuscripts in preparation

In prep **Borghi, O.**, Tsakiris, M., Von Mohr, M. B. (in preparation). Is democracy worth the effort? Seeing the other side as willing strengthens pro-democratic motivation.

Submitted **Borghi, O.**, Lawall, K., Smets, K., Tsakiris, M. (submitted at JEP: General). Future Anxiety Affects Youth's Democratic Support and Engagement.

in prep **Borghi, O.***, Günes, M. T.*, Tsakiris, M., Lamm, C., & Martins, M. J. D. (in preparation). Uncovering the moral foundations of polarized movie reviews.

Datasets

2025 Smets, K., Arahal, I., Bakker, B. N., Barkas, D., **Borghi, O.**, … Wichary, S. (2025). *IP-PAD Wave 2: Online study*. [Data set]. OSF. https://osf.io/dakwm/

2024 Smets, K., Arahal, I., Bakker, B., Barkas, D., Bathelt, J., **Borghi, O.**, … Wichary, S. (2024). *IP-PAD Wave 1: Online study.* [Data set]. OSF. https://osf.io/fmn5r/

** Equal author contributions.*
† Undergraduate's or master's level publications

Conferences and Public Engagement

Interviews and podcasts

04/2026 **Guest expert,** Bridging Divides | British Red Cross podcast and initiative
Episode 2: Can we really change people's minds?
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bRmexgvjphU

Conference and departmental talks

03/2026 **Anxious, apathetic, and antidemocratic? Future anxiety and young people's political attitudes**
Developmental and Educational Psychology, Leiden University.

03/2026 **Anxious, apathetic, and antidemocratic? Future anxiety and young people's political attitudes**
Workshop: Politics and Mental Health in Times of Societal Threat. Institute for Advanced Study (IAS) Amsterdam.

02/2026 **Future Anxiety and young people's support for democracy**
24 hrs of Political Psychology, University of Vienna.

09/2025 **Facing a Dark Future: Young people's future anxiety and political attitudes.**
BPS Developmental Psychology Section Annual Conference, Royal Holloway, University of London.

06/2025 **Mind over bias: How is cognitive control related to politically motivated reasoning?**
48th Annual Scientific Meeting of the International Society of Political Psychology (ISPP), Prague.

10/2024 **The link between cognitive control and motivated reasoning from an interdisciplinary perspective.**
PGR Conference, Department of Psychology, Royal Holloway, University of London.

10/2023 **Day-to-day association between mindfulness and perceived stress, and how to investigate psychological chicken-and-egg problems.**
PGR Conference, Department of Psychology, Royal Holloway, University of London.

Poster presentations

11/2025 **Borghi, O.** Facing a Dark Future: Young people's future anxiety and political attitudes. *IP-PAD Meeting Open Conference Day, Amsterdam. View poster*

06/2023 **Borghi, O., Lamm, C., & Boch, M.** Modulation of the Action Observation Network by Action, Agent and Observer Factors: Insights from an fMRI Study on Dog-Experts and Non-Experts. *ECR Poster Session, Faculty of Psychology, Vienna. View poster*

Research Visits & Summer Schools

03/2026 **Cognition in Development Lab** | Leiden University | Research visit, host: Ili Ma.

07/2025 **Open Research Summer School 2025** | King's College London

01/2025	**ISPP Virtual Academy Fellow**
07/2024	**Birmingham–Leiden Summer School** | Computational Social Cognition

Academic Service

Peer review

Ad-hoc reviewer for *Cognition*, *Journal of Experimental Social Psychology*, *Mindfulness*, and *InMind Magazine*.

Conference service

09/2025	**Steward** | BPS Developmental Psychology Section Annual Conference, Royal Holloway, University of London.
06/2025	**Panel co-organiser & chair:** Interdisciplinary Perspectives on Young People's Political Agency and Voting Rights. *48th ISPP, Prague.*
06/2025	**Panel chair:** Biological and Psychometric Approaches. *48th ISPP, Prague.*
07/2022	**Steward** | 6th International Conference of the European Society for Cognitive and Affective Neuroscience (ESCAN), University of Vienna

Representative & committee roles

2025/26	**Doctoral Candidate Representative** | Marie Skłodowska-Curie Actions IP-PAD Network
2024/25	**PGR Representative** | Department of Psychology, Royal Holloway, University of London

Skills

Data acquisition

- Online experiment and questionnaire implementation using Gorilla, Qualtrics, and Prolific
- Extensive training and certification for Siemens Magnetom Skyra MR system.
- Eye-tracking with Eyelink 1000 Plus (SR Research, Ontario, Canada).

Data analysis & coding

- **R** — advanced proficiency in data cleaning, visualisation and advanced statistical analyses including (Bayesian) multilevel modelling (e.g., using *brms, lme4, lavaan, ggplot2, marginaleffects*)
- **Python** — data analysis and visualization with *numpy* and *pandas*; MRI data analysis with *Nipype*, *Nilearn*, and *Nibabel*.
- fMRI data analysis in FSL; basic bash scripting.
- Git and version control (basic).
- Open science methods: pre-registration, simulating and diagnosing research designs with DeclareDesign, and safeguard power analysis.
- Other software: JASP and SPSS (advanced statistics), G*Power (power analysis), ITK-SNAP (manual brain segmentation).

Languages

- **German** — native.
- **English** — C2; proficient in writing, reading, and speaking.
- **Italian** — B2 / C1.